

Aristea of the Shifting Tides

Level 17-25 Optimization and Advancement Guide



Tide. Frost. Form. Arcane craftsmanship.

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Aristea should remain a Wizard-centered ray specialist, water-and-cold controller, shapeshifter, and primary item creator. Her distinctive damage engine is the campaign ruling that allows each ray to apply sneak attack together with Merciful Spell, Benthic Spell, Sap Adept, Sap Master, and the always-on Vital Strike-like artifact effect. Do not replace that engine with generic blaster advice.

Her immediate order is:

1. Release her soul from Tartarus and restore her before applying advancement choices.
2. Reconstruct the actual level-17 sheet: school, archetype, mythic path/tier, feats, spells, items, ray routine, and Animal Lord template tier.
3. Continue Wizard through 20 unless the existing sheet proves a multiclass or prestige commitment.
4. Complete Spell Perfection (scorching ray), spell-resistance penetration, and ray-targeting support before buying secondary damage feats.
5. Use mythic choices on Seeking Spell (Mythic), Piercing Spell (Mythic), Eldritch Breach, flexible arcane casting, and action economy.
6. Preserve her unique crafting advantage: dwarven wizard favored-class acceleration plus the three-times-speed demiplane.
7. Adapt Nereus's Deific Obedience from printed Gozreh boons rather than inventing benefits above the printed power ceiling.

Confirmed starting point

Category	Confirmed state at level 17
Class	Wizard 17
Ancestry	Elf
Alignment	Neutral good
Deity	Nereus
Divine mantle	Animal Lord of the Tides; sacred narwhal form
Party role	Damage specialist, item creator, shapeshifter, merchant-mage, navigator
Magic themes	Water, cold, controlled transformation, dwarven runic structure
Campaign crafting	Dwarven wizard favored-class acceleration and a three-times-speed demiplane
Campaign combat	Special ray/sneak-attack interaction; Merciful and Benthic scorching ray; Sap Adept and Sap Master interaction
Current status	Dead; body survived; soul imprisoned in Tartarus

The records do not establish her school, archetype, mythic path/tier, exact feats, spellbook, items, or ability scores. Recommendations are therefore ordered queues, not claims about the current sheet.

Recovery gate

No resurrection spell can restore Aristea while her soul remains imprisoned. The correct sequence is: locate the soul, reach Tartarus, break or bypass the prison, extract the soul, and only then use mythic resurrection, true resurrection, or the campaign's Perfect Resurrection. Build resources should not be spent on redundant resurrection attempts before extraction.

Recommended class progression

Primary track - published endpoint first

Character level	Class level	Main gain and action
17	Wizard 17	Current state. Reconstruct the sheet before changing anything.
18	Wizard 18	Expand 9th-level preparation and spellbook depth. Secure time stop, shapechange, and wish as available.
19	Wizard 19	Complete the first missing ray or spell-resistance feat.
20	Wizard 20	Take the Wizard bonus feat and preserve the published school/capstone endpoint.
21	Epic Wizard 21 if defined	Continue spellbook, school, and familiar/bond advancement under the campaign epic table.
22	Epic Wizard 22	Advance the primary casting engine.
23	Epic Wizard 23	Add the next ray, control, or crafting feat.
24	Epic Wizard 24	Prepare for level-10/11 arcane spell access.
25	Epic Wizard 25	Add the final priority feat and complete the first epic spell package.

Fallback when epic Wizard is undefined

After Wizard 20, Evangelist of Nereus is the thematic fallback only if Aligned Class advances Wizard beyond 20. Character levels 21-25 become Evangelist 1-5, with Wizard advancement delayed at Evangelist 1 and resumed at Evangelist 2. Do not enter merely to accelerate Deific Obedience: a level-20 worshiper already reaches all three normal feat boons. Loremaster is the cleaner neutral fallback if it advances the table's epic spellcasting and Evangelist does not.

Standard feat plan

Preserve before retraining

- Merciful Spell and Benthic Spell while the current scorching-ray engine remains legal.
- Sap Adept and Sap Master while the campaign ruling continues to apply them to the ray routine.
- Existing item-creation feats that define her role as primary crafter.
- Any prerequisite feats supporting the always-on Vital Strike-like artifact effect.

Feat queue

Aristea receives ordinary feats at levels 19, 21, 23, and 25, plus a Wizard bonus feat at level 20. At each opportunity, take the first legal missing option.

Priority	Standard feat	Function
1	Spell Perfection - Scorching Ray	Removes metamagic cost from the signature ray and improves qualifying feat bonuses. Requires three metamagic feats and Spellcraft 15.
2	Spell Focus - Evocation	Foundation for ray and cold DCs and a Rod of Spell Focusing upgrade.
3	Greater Spell Focus - Evocation	Increases save pressure on cold and area evocations.
4	Spell Penetration	Begins the spell-resistance package.
5	Greater Spell Penetration	Necessary against epic and mythic resistance.
6	Seeking Spell	Third-party prerequisite for the mythic ray-targeting upgrade; verify the selected source wording.

Priority	Standard feat	Function
7	Piercing Spell	Third-party metamagic prerequisite for the mythic spell-resistance upgrade.
8	Rime Spell	Adds movement control to qualifying cold spells.
9	Craft Staff	Core infrastructure feat if not already owned.
10	Craft Tige Vierge	Super Genius Games option that front-loads staff construction and finishes the spell binding in one day; requires Int 17, CL 11, Craft Staff, and GM approval.

Recommended placement if the first five priorities are already satisfied: level 19 Seeking Spell, level 20 Wizard bonus feat Craft Staff, level 21 Piercing Spell, level 23 Rime Spell, and level 25 Craft Tige Vierge. If Spell Perfection or penetration is missing, those displace this schedule.

Mythic path ability order

Confirm Aristea's actual path before selecting. The following assumes Archmage access or approved universal/cross-path access.

Priority	Mythic path ability	Function
1	Wild Arcana	Flexible access to an arcane spell without preparation; best general Wizard surge.
2	Eldritch Breach	Roll twice to overcome spell resistance and on dispel-related caster-level checks.
3	Arcane Metamastery	Apply a needed metamagic feat without preparation or slot increase.
4	Spell Dilation	Legendary Games option that reshapes area dimensions for water, ice, fog, wall, and battlefield-control spells.
5	Wallbuilder	Strengthens and can relocate wall effects; ideal for wall of ice, wall of force, and shipboard partitions.
6	Arcanist's Escape	Tier-6 emergency dimension door when grappled, pinned, or entangled; can bypass some nonmythic teleport blocks at high cost.
7	Channel Power	High-tier damage amplifier for the one encounter where ray burst must end the threat immediately.
8	Mythic Spellpower	Expand mythic spell flexibility after survival and penetration are secured.

Mythic feat order

Priority	Mythic feat	Prerequisite/check	Reason
1	Mythic Spell Lore	Mythic spellcasting eligibility	Establishes a flexible mythic spell portfolio.
2	Seeking Spell (Mythic)	Seeking Spell	Explicitly supports ranged attacks and ranged touch attacks and reduces cover problems.
3	Piercing Spell (Mythic)	Piercing Spell	Substantially reduces effective spell resistance for damaging rays.
4	Improved Initiative (Mythic)	Improved Initiative	Lets Aristea exploit a target immediately after Demidius strips its defenses.
5	Spell Penetration (Mythic)	Spell Penetration	Additional reliability against mythic spell resistance.
6	Rime Spell (Mythic)	Rime Spell	On-demand cold control and stronger movement denial.
7	Extra Mythic Power	None beyond mythic status	Fuels Wild Arcana, Arcane Metamastery, Seeking, Piercing, and emergency movement.
8	Spell Focus (Mythic) - Evocation	Spell Focus (evocation)	Best after touch accuracy and spell resistance are already solved.

The current campaign gives one Mythic Power point for every mythic feat. Do not count a bought feat twice if another ability grants it as a bonus feat.

Deific Obedience - Nereus

Deific Obedience boons are separate from spendable campaign Boons. Inner Sea Gods explicitly permits adapting boons for lesser or custom deities by borrowing same-level benefits from comparable gods.

Proposed obedience

Spend one hour beside open water or a vessel of natural seawater. Sound shell or driftwood chimes, trace a tidal rune in salt, recount one truth learned through patience, and return clean water to the sea. Use Gozreh's printed obedience power ceiling: a +4 sacred bonus on saving throws against electricity and water spells and effects for neutral-good Aristea.

Printed-model boon package

Boon tier	Nereus adaptation	Printed model	Advice
1	Weather Watcher	Gozreh, Evangelist 1	Endure elements 3/day, resist energy 2/day, or protection from energy 1/day. Excellent expedition protection.
2	Child of the Deep	Gozreh, Exalted 2 Lightning Child	Use the printed electricity resistance of 5 + Hit Dice. It supports sea travel without inventing a stronger benefit.
3	Elemental Ally	Gozreh, Evangelist 3	Summon a greater water elemental through the printed summon monster VII model. Strong, thematic, and within precedent.

At ordinary Deific Obedience timing, a level-17 character has the first two boons and gains the third at 20 Hit Dice. If the campaign's Nereus relationship uses different timing, record it explicitly. Animal Lord of the Tides is a spendable-Boon template and should not be counted as a Deific Obedience boon unless the GM says so.

Spendable campaign Boons

1. Confirm the current Animal Lord template tier. Do not repurchase the Lesser template if already granted.
2. Upgrade Animal Lord to Greater for three additional Boons if the upgrade materially improves narwhal form, combat casting, or sea operations.
3. Upgrade to Master for five additional Boons only after reviewing the exact template text.
4. Buy Seeking Spell (Mythic) and Piercing Spell (Mythic) while their escalating mythic-feat cost remains low and their base prerequisites are complete.
5. Save five Boons for adoption by Nereus if Aristea wants divine bloodline progression and the adoption does not overwrite another lineage.
6. Save the next five Boons for demigod rank. Each gained godly power is unusually efficient because it also adds one Mythic Tier and two Mythic Power points under the campaign rules.
7. Mortal God is the later 10-Boon target.

Because Aristea is currently trapped, bank all new awards until she is recovered unless the GM permits her soul to receive or spend Boons in Tartarus.

Nonmythic spell acquisition order

Signature ray package

1. Scorching ray - primary perfected spell when the Merciful/Benthic/Sap engine is active.

- 2. Battering blast - force-based ranged touch option that avoids elemental resistance and supports repositioning.
- 3. Disintegrate - high-value ranged touch attack and utility against objects and force effects.
- 4. Polar ray - no-save cold ray with strong thematic fit; plan for cold resistance and immunity.
- 5. Hellfire ray only after alignment, descriptor, and campaign consequences are checked.

Water and cold control

- 1. Icy prison and mass icy prison.
- 2. Wall of ice, wall of force, and forcecage.
- 3. Control water and control weather for naval operations.
- 4. Hydraulic torrent, geyser, ice spears, and cold ice strike for movement and area pressure.
- 5. Sirocco for fatigue/exhaustion control when fire is tactically acceptable.
- 6. Polar midnight as a late battlefield effect, not the default opener.

Shapeshifting

- 1. Shapechange - premier high-level form toolbox.
- 2. Elemental body and form of the dragon series for specific defenses, movement, and senses.
- 3. Monstrous physique and beast shape for efficient lower-slot forms.
- 4. Preserve sacred narwhal form for underwater travel, sonar-like perception, and Nereus symbolism rather than treating it as a generic combat form.

Defense and action economy

- Mind blank, contingency, emergency force sphere, mirror image, displacement, greater invisibility, seamantle, freedom of movement, spell turning, and time stop.
- Prepare at least one immediate or swift defense that does not consume the same action needed for mythic ray enhancement.
- Use a contingency for extraction or survival, not a routine damage trigger.

Crafting and infrastructure

- Fabricate, permanency, greater create demiplane, mage's private sanctum, teleportation circle, planar binding, greater teleport, and wish.
- Build custom staves around water/cold control, emergency movement, and spells Aristea does not want to prepare daily.
- Use the three-times-speed demiplane for crafting only after the GM confirms how outside deadlines, rest, and material delivery interact with accelerated time.

Mythic spell acquisition order

The Mythic Spell Compendium sweep was scored for Demidius, so Aristea's ranking below is a character-specific reinterpretation of verified spell text rather than a claim that the database's Demidius rating applies to her.

Priority	Mythic spell	Aristea use
1	Icy Prison	Strengthens the prison and cold damage; excellent single-target control.
2	Shapechange	Broadens the form toolbox and supports her identity as a controlled shapeshifter.
3	Teleport or Greater Teleport	Safer group movement, retrieval, and escape.

Priority	Mythic spell	Aristea use
4	Control Water	Enlarges the affected water and adds dangerous sea-state control.
5	Permanency	Protect crafted infrastructure and permanent ship/demiplane magic.
6	Greater Dispel Magic	Secondary anti-magic capability when Demidius is occupied or absent.
7	Cold Ice Strike	Stronger mixed physical/cold damage when a swift-area attack is valuable.
8	Elemental Body	Flexible elemental forms and defenses.
9	Freedom of Movement	Defensive answer for an arcane caster who cannot afford to be pinned.
10	Gate	Planar retrieval and expedition utility after the Tartarus crisis.

Do not select a mythic scorching ray until its exact approved source and interaction with the campaign ray/sneak-attack ruling are verified.

Epic spell priorities

Epic spells require an approved level-10/11 slot and learning table.

First level-10 arcane choices

1. Enchant Item - best match for the primary crafter.
2. Master Finished Work I - accelerate or perfect major construction under the campaign text.
3. Create Gate / Teleport Circle - permanent logistics and expedition access.
4. Perfect Resurrection - recovery capability after a soul is free.
5. Cloak of the Gods - durable personal defense.
6. Epic Shadow Evocation - flexible access if the reconstructed text is approved.

First level-11 arcane choices

1. Master Finished Work II.
2. Enchant Item II.
3. Epic Dispel Magic.
4. Absorb Energy - converts a selected energy type into healing for its duration.
5. Epic Particulate Form - defense and transformation theme.
6. Create Roaming Hungry Pit - mobile no-SR battlefield control.
7. Form of Giant IV only when the form's statistics improve an actual mission.

Level-by-level action plan

Level	Class and feat action	Spell priority	Strategic goal
17	Recover soul; reconstruct sheet	Contingency, mind blank, ray package	Restore before rebuilding
18	Wizard 18	Time stop, shapechange, wish	Complete 9th-level toolbox
19	Wizard 19; first missing ray feat	Icy prison, polar ray	Improve signature offense
20	Wizard 20; Craft Staff or missing core feat	Permanency, teleportation circle	Finish published Wizard chassis
21	Epic Wizard or approved fallback	Control water/weather suite	Expand naval control
22	Advance approved caster chassis	Greater demiplane and planar tools	Restore infrastructure role
23	Next missing penetration/control feat	Mythic spell portfolio expansion	Defeat SR and cover reliably
24	Prepare epic spell access	Enchant Item / Master Finished Work	Accelerate strategic crafting
25	Final priority feat	Epic Dispel / Absorb Energy	Operate at epic encounter scale

Combat doctrine

1. Let Demidius identify and strip mind blank, spell turning, energy immunity, and freedom effects.
2. Act immediately after the dispel and target touch AC with the perfected ray package.
3. Use Seeking and Piercing effects only when cover or spell resistance actually matters; conserve mythic power otherwise.
4. Convert cold damage or switch to force/disintegration when cold immunity remains.
5. Use Icy Prison, walls, and water control when a full ray burst would waste resources or endanger allies.
6. Shapechange for mission capabilities, not merely the largest statistics.
7. Withdraw with Arcanist's Escape, contingency, or teleport before being pinned or silenced.

GM decisions required

- What are Aristea's school, archetype, opposition schools, arcane bond, and exact feats?
- What are her mythic path, tier, path abilities, mythic feats, and mythic spells?
- Does every ray still apply sneak attack, and how do Merciful, Benthic, Sap Adept, and Sap Master combine?
- What is the exact Animal Lord template tier and upgrade text?
- Does Aristea qualify for the dwarven Wizard favored-class bonus despite being an elf, and what is its exact crafting multiplier?
- Does the demiplane produce exactly three days of crafting per outside day, and how are rest and supplies handled?
- Is Seeking Spell and Piercing Spell material approved, and which printed versions control?
- Is Nereus's obedience package borrowed from Gozreh as proposed?
- What epic Wizard and level-10/11 spell table applies?

Sources

- Pathfinder Roleplaying Game: Mythic Adventures, Archmage and universal abilities pp. 14-19 and 50-51; mythic feats pp. 54-77.
- Inner Sea Gods, Gozreh obedience and boons pp. 68-75; custom deity and prestige framework pp. 194-217.
- Mythic Spell Compendium, relevant entries for Icy Prison, Shapechange, Teleport, Control Water, Permanency, Greater Dispel Magic, Cold Ice Strike, Elemental Body, and Gate.
- Mythic Minis 14, 36, and 51, especially Spell Dilation, Wallbuilder, Arcanist's Escape, Seeking Spell (Mythic), Piercing Spell (Mythic), and Rime Spell (Mythic), PDF pp. 2-3.
- Mythic Rods, Rod of Spell Focusing, PDF p. 2; Mythic Jewels, Diamond of Everwinter, PDF p. 2.
- Super Genius Games targeted extraction, Craft Tige Vierge, Magic Staff Emporium PDF pp. 3-4.
- Epic Spell Compendium, campaign transcription and reconstruction.
- Aristea project page, campaign backstory, Legendary Games deep dive, and current campaign-rule summaries.